

vendors. The Department of Justice (DoJ) investigation into the sale of each of these patents will push out the company's acquisition from March to at least April 12, 2011.

According to a Form 8-K legal affidavit filed by Novell on 4th March in response to a second request for information from the DOJ, Novell and the Microsoft consortium "...have agreed to provide the DOJ with additional time to review the patent sale and not to close the patent sale prior to April 12, 2011. The company remains committed to working with the DOJ as it conducts its review of the patent sale."

Foursquare for Android updated!

Although adopted by a very niche segment in India — limited only to the metros — Foursquare is one of the most popular and successful location-based or 'check-in' apps elsewhere. The team behind this app has been working hard and has come out with a version that makes a huge leap forward, Foursquare 3.0, for Android.

First, the addition of a new 'Explore' tab lets you search for interesting places within your city. Searches for food, recreational places or anything else will return results that are local in nature. Also, the leaderboard, where you track all your and your friends' activities, now has a seven-day shelf-life, being reset every Sunday. So every Saturday there would be a 'leaderboard for Saturday' night — as the team puts it — to know where your friends have been in the past week and encourage you to explore more.

Last but not the least, and certainly the most interesting, the 'Specials' section lists all the merchants in your area that offer discounts, encouraging you to check-in at their location. Based on your regularity at those locations, you would be offered the appropriate offer. Foursquare will be adding six types of 'Specials' for merchants to offer varied discounts. Start exploring!

Chrome's URL bar could soon be extinct

Google is exploring several 'major' changes to its Chrome browser user interface (UI) to make it even more radical, including the potential removal of the address bar from the standard Chrome interface. The address bar currently takes up a significant amount of space that could be used for Web browsing.

An e-mail sent to the Chromium developer mailing list by product manager Jeff Chang indicates that Google has, "...a number of UI/front-end efforts under way" for Chrome. The new 'compact' navigation mode that calls for the removal of the bar, would take the Web address bar out of each tab, releasing more screen space to display Web pages.

The 'hidden' address bar would appear when a page is loading and whenever a user clicks on the tab of a given page itself. "If we take the address bar out of the tab, it can be used as both a launcher and switcher; users do not have to worry about replacing their active tab," says Google.

The Chrome UI variants page mentions that the Internet titan is considering four different layouts — with four different types of navigation: classic navigation, compact navigation, sidetab navigation as well as a touchscreen version. Google is currently 'interested' in developing all four versions, but current builds of Chrome "...are focused on classic and compact navigation styles."

Android 2.4 coming out this April

Just before the media got a preview of the newest version of Honeycomb, Android chief Andy Rubin had some special words for the engineers behind the open source OS, acknowledging them to be the "hardest working team in mobile" currently. We all would have to agree with him given the speed with which Android updates are rolled out. Late last year, in December, we got Gingerbread. This year at the CES, we got Honeycomb. And in April, in all probability, we'd be getting Android 2.4. It is no surprise that manufacturers are finding it hard to keep up with the updates, customise them and finally roll them out to consumers.

Sources inside Viewsonic have told tech blog Pocket-Lint that its smartphone ViewPad 4 would come out in April and would run on Android 2.4 — which to everybody's surprise won't be called Ice-Cream (as was popularly assumed) but will continue to use the Gingerbread tag! Android 2.4 would be designed to support dual-core apps that run on the tablet-optimised Honeycomb. This was what Google spokesperson Andrew Kovacs might have meant when he said that "...some of the features of Honeycomb will find their way into smartphones with future Android releases."

Barring a few UI enhancements, bug fixes and other updates, Gingerbread wasn't particularly exciting. This is the reason why manufacturers worldwide haven't shown any urgency in adopting 2.3 — except for the Nexus S. Android 2.4 would continue to sport the Gingerbread tag since the only update would be support for dual-core apps.

The source at Viewsonic also believes that Ice-Cream may not be totally dead but might be the next iteration in the 3.0 series of updates. Viewsonic's ViewPad would sport Android 2.4, Flash 10.1, a 5 MP camera, 720p HD-video recording and playback via mini-HDMI.